From a young age, I have been a fan of Nicki Minaj and her music (Nicki's Wikipedia page can be found here: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Nicki_Minaj). In high school, I began exploring more of Nicki's music beyond her mainstream songs, and found that she pays homage to countless different places throughout her work. These include cities and neighborhoods that she and other artists are tied to, along with states, countries, and larger world regions. For this project, I will produce a map of the locations that Nicki Minaj has referenced across her discography, along with the average year that each location was mentioned.

By mapping this information, I aim to broaden the viewer's perspective of Nicki's versatility. I also hope to inform the viewer about some of Nicki's personal history. I will illustrate this information in the aesthetic of one of my favorite of Nicki's alter egos, the Harajuku Barbie. This is characterized by maximalism, gaudy accessories, and vivid colors including hot pink. I am excited to experiment with this aesthetic, as it contrasts the minimalistic look that I have built in much of my previous work.

I have acquired most of the necessary data I need, including a huggingface.co dataset of lyrics from every song that Nicki owns or is featured in. Using assistance from Microsoft Copilot and software packages including pandas, json, regex, and spacy, I wrote a Python script to detect and compile words that represent locations and their frequency in the dataset. I then manually sorted the data into categories by geography type (continent/world region, country, state, city, etc.) in Microsoft Excel. To determine the average year, I am in the process of manually analyzing each location's instances and adding the year of their song's release as an additional attribute. I will then take the average of these years for each location. To georeference the "location" words, I will download shapefiles of countries and U.S. states (https://www.naturalearthdata.com/), and cities (https://simplemaps.com/data/us-cities). I can represent some locations using only a point, whose coordinates I will obtain from Google Maps (such as the Buckingham Palace). To decorate the map layout, I will also include pictures of Nicki herself, which I will download from Google Images. I do not have exact sources yet for those pictures.

I expect to create a static map with a main world map layout and additional inset maps of the U.S. and New York City metro area, since many of the locations that Nicki mentions are in or around these smaller areas. My map will also include a title, caption, and a legend. I will likely use choropleth to represent the average year of locations, and some type of proportional symbol to represent the location's frequency. I prefer to use these visualization types where I can classify the data into ranges of values, because there are likely several errors from the dataset itself, the spacy algorithm, and my own manipulation of the data (although the original dataset is very large, so I believe it is still an accurate representation of Nicki's location references overall). Additionally, as an intriguing final touch, I could attach callouts to certain cities or other enumeration units, and reference the lyric(s) that that place is featured in.

I will use several technologies for this project. As stated before, I used Python, Microsoft Copilot, and Excel for the initial data processing. I will then use ArcGIS Pro to create the map, and Adobe Illustrator to attach images, icons (for cities and point locations), and final text and designs to the map. If I have time, I may also create a storymap (ArcGIS Story Maps) explaining my inspiration and design process.

While the topic of this project does not relate to my professional goals, it will still be a helpful exercise in developing skills that I may use in my career. For example, I used Python code and revised and troubleshooted with assistance from Copilot. I performed data analysis in Excel, including sorting, filtering, conditional formatting, and pivot tables. I will also go through the cartographic process and practice my own artistic expression through graphic design, using the technologies I listed before.

Rough layout of final project: